



JOHNS HOPKINS

WHITING SCHOOL
of ENGINEERING

∂ CBDs: Differentiable Causal Block Diagrams

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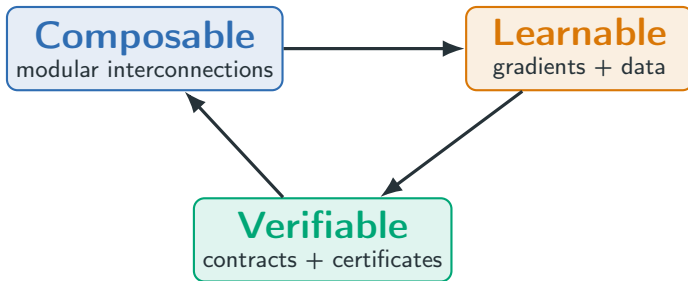
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Motivation: Next Generation Cyber-Physical Systems (CPS)



Modern CPS need the integration of composability, verifiability, and learning

Existing frameworks and modeling languages usually optimize one or two properties, but rarely provide all three in a single executable modeling pipeline.

Language 1: Causal Block Diagrams (CBD)

Formal object

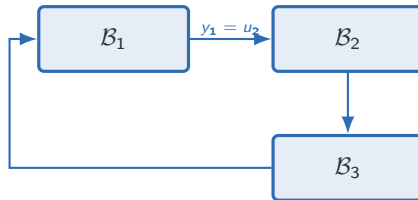
$$\mathcal{B} = (U, X, Y, T, F, g, \text{Init})$$

Block is defined by inputs, states, outputs, time semantics, state transitions, output map, and initial condition.

Closure under composition

$$\mathcal{D} = (\{\mathcal{B}_i\}_{i=1}^N, \Sigma)$$

A CBD is a collection of causal blocks $\mathcal{B}_i$ connected by typed signal wires Σ . Each block maps input signals to output signals through state and output semantics, satisfying causality.



Composable by construction: serial, parallel, and feedback composition preserve interface, state, and time semantics, allowing hierarchical subsystems to be collapsed into a single equivalent block.

Language 2: Differentiable Programs

Formal object

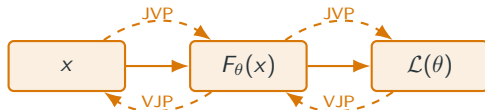
$$F_\theta : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m, \quad \mathcal{L}(\theta) = \ell(F_\theta(x), y)$$

A differentiable program is an executable computational graph whose intermediate operations expose derivative information.

Local derivative actions

$$\text{JVP}(v) = J_F v, \quad \text{VJP}(\bar{v}) = J_F^\top \bar{v}$$

AD propagates local Jacobian actions rather than forming the full Jacobian.



Composable by chain rule: elementary differentiable operators compose into larger computational graphs, and local Jacobian actions enable efficient end-to-end gradient propagation.

However, the semantics are primarily numerical, with limited native support for modular correctness, contracts, or formal verification.

Language 3: Assume–Guarantee Contracts

Formal object

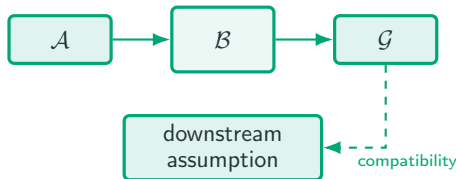
$$\mathcal{C}^{\text{AG}} = (\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{G})$$

The environment must satisfy assumptions $\mathcal{A}$; the component $\mathcal{B}$ then guarantees behavior in $\mathcal{G}$.

Modular Reasoning

$$U \in \mathcal{A} \implies (U, \mathcal{B}(U)) \in \mathcal{G}$$

Contracts support modular reasoning: upstream guarantees must satisfy downstream assumptions. Local contracts compose hierarchically, allowing system-level correctness to be derived from component-level specifications.



Composable by refinement: local assumptions and guarantees compose across interfaces, enabling scalable hierarchical verification and abstraction.

However, contract reasoning is traditionally separated from differentiable optimization and data-driven learning.

The Gap: Three Powerful Languages, Weakly Connected

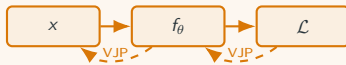
CBDs



Pros: Great for modular CPS design.

Cons: Not differentiable; hard to optimize.

Differentiable programs



Pros: Great for optimization and learning.

Cons: Limited semantic structure for correctness and reasoning.

Contracts



Pros: Great for modular reasoning.

Cons: Disconnected from learning.

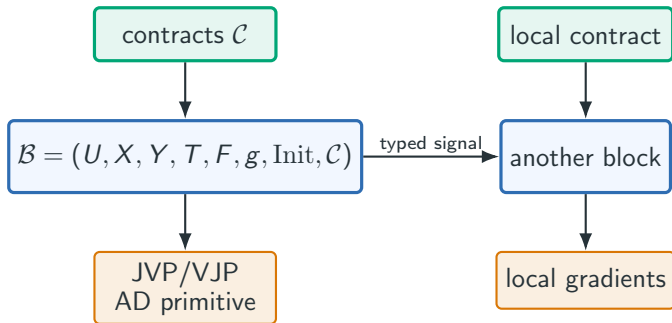
Question:

Can a CPS diagram be simultaneously a causal model, a differentiable program, and a contract-carrying object?

Our answer: Differentiable Causal Block Diagrams (∂ CBDs)

Informal Definition

A ∂ CBD is a causal block diagram whose blocks expose execution semantics, contract semantics, and local derivative actions.



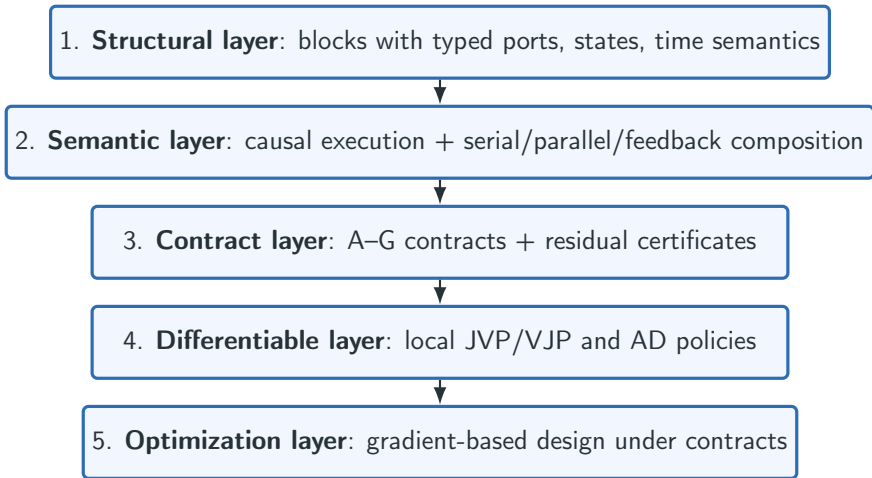
Contracts guide learning; gradients make contracts trainable; CBDs preserve modular structure.

Position paper presenting vision for next generation semantics for CPS:

1. **Differentiable CBD formalism:** blocks preserve causal execution semantics while exposing AD-compatible derivative operations.
2. **Contract integration:** assume–guarantee contracts for semantic correctness and residual contracts for differentiable certificates.
3. **AD-ready reduction:** rate lifting, branch expansion, feedback unrolling, and topological sorting compile ∂ CBDs to finite-horizon DAGs.
4. **Verifiable optimization layer:** objectives and contract residuals are optimized jointly by gradient-based methods.

∂ CBDs turn block diagrams into differentiable programs with modular composition and verification.

Five-layer abstraction of ∂ CBDs

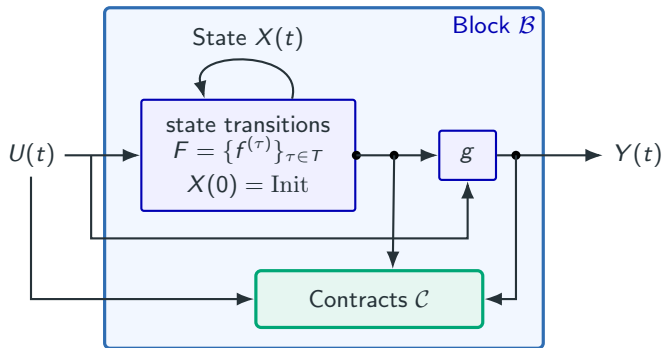


Each layer adds structure without discarding the semantics of the previous layer.

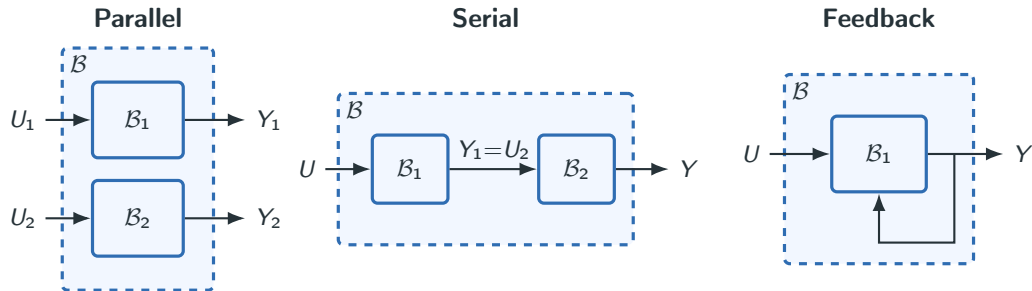
Block with a contract

$$\mathcal{B} = (U, X, Y, T, F, g, \text{Init}, \mathcal{C})$$

- U, X, Y : input, state, output signals
- T : continuous/discrete/hybrid time semantics
- F : state transitions or dynamics
- g : output map or implicit solver
- Init : initial conditions
- $\mathcal{C}$: contract annotations



The same object is used for simulation, verification, and differentiation.



Key property

Composition rules preserve CBD structure: Algebraic-loop-free CBDs can be flattened into a directed acyclic graph (DAG) of blocks; nested subsystems may be represented by heterogeneous blocks while preserving interface semantics.

Contract layer

A–G contracts

$$\mathcal{C}^{\text{AG}} = (\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{G}),$$

$$U \in \mathcal{A} \Rightarrow (U, \mathcal{B}(U)) \in \mathcal{G}$$

System-wide quantitative certificates
Enable modular correctness reasoning

$$\mathcal{C}_{\parallel}^{\text{res}} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathcal{C}_1^{\text{res}}(X_1, U_1, Y_1) \\ \mathcal{C}_2^{\text{res}}(X_2, U_2, Y_2) \end{bmatrix} \leq 0$$

$$\mathcal{C}_{; }^{\text{res}} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathcal{C}_1^{\text{res}}(X_1, U_1, Y_1) \\ \mathcal{C}_2^{\text{res}}(X_2, (U_2^-, Y_1^\sigma), Y_2) \end{bmatrix} \leq 0$$

$$\mathcal{C}_{\circ}^{\text{res}} = \mathcal{C}^{\text{res}}(X, (U^-, Y^\sigma), Y) \leq 0$$

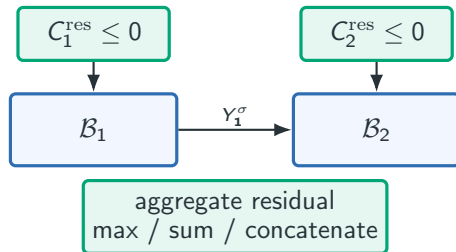
Residual contracts

$$\mathcal{C}^{\text{res}}(X, U, Y; \theta) \leq 0$$

Quantitative certificates on executions

Differentiable and AD-compatible

Compatible with physics-informed machine learning



Residual contracts bridge formal specifications and numerical optimization, and follow the same signal substitutions as the CBD execution semantics.

Almost-everywhere differentiability assumption

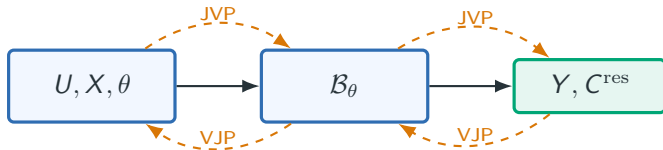
State transitions $f^{(\tau)}$, output maps g , and residuals $\mathcal{C}^{\text{res}}$ are locally Lipschitz and differentiable almost everywhere, with a declared policy at isolated nonsmooth points.

$$\text{JVP}(v) = J_F v$$

Forward sensitivity propagation via
Jacobian-vector product (JVP)

$$\text{VJP}(\bar{v}) = J_F^\top \bar{v}$$

Reverse-mode adjoint propagation via
Vector-Jacobian product (VJP).



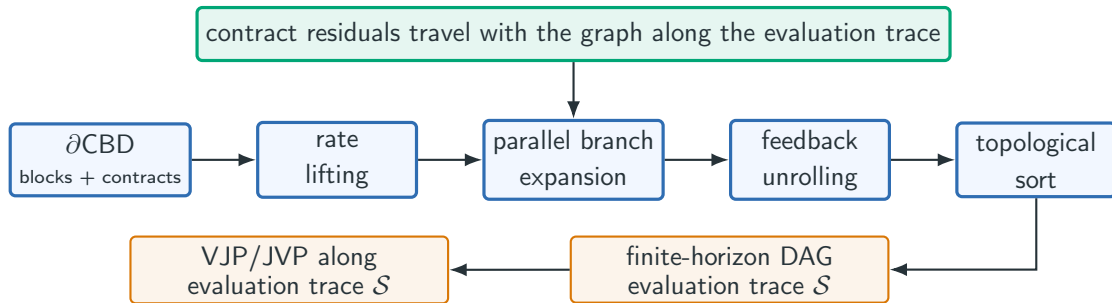
Differentiable blocks expose local JVP/VJP operations.

Differentiable layer: Heterogeneous blocks with AD primitives

Block type	AD primitive
Discrete-time dynamics	Unroll dynamics; backpropagation through time (BPTT)
Continuous-time dynamics	Adjoint state methods
Neural components	Native automatic differentiation through layers via VJP
Fixed-point / implicit blocks	Differentiate via the implicit function theorem (IFT)
Optimization layers	Differentiate KKT systems via IFT
Integer / logic ports	Declared relaxation, estimator, or surrogate-gradient policy
Control flow	AD over realized evaluation trace

The ∂ CBD framework can mix physical simulators, neural networks, controllers, implicit solvers, and optimization layers in one contract-aware computational graph.

Differentiable layer: Reduction to an AD-ready DAG



AD applies local Jacobian actions along the evaluation trace.

Differentiable Causal Block Diagrams (∂ CBD)

Causal Block Diagram (CBD)

A CBD is a composition of blocks $\mathcal{D} = (\mathcal{B}, \Sigma)$, $\mathcal{B} = \{\mathcal{B}_i\}_{i=1}^N$ with unilateral typed signal connections $\Sigma = \{\sigma_{i,j} \mid \mathcal{B}_i \in \mathcal{B}, \mathcal{B}_j \in \mathcal{B}\}$. Its execution defines the composite map

$$(X, Y) \in \text{Exec}(\mathcal{D}, U).$$

Serial, parallel, and feedback composition preserve interface, state, and time semantics.

Differentiable CBD (∂ CBD)

The CBD $\mathcal{D}$ becomes *differentiable* if:

1. each $\mathcal{B}_i$ exposes local JVP/VJP rules;
2. Σ is type-consistent and feedback-admissible;
3. the execution map $\text{Exec}(\mathcal{D}, U)$ is differentiable a.e.

Composable model $\Rightarrow$ differentiable execution $\Rightarrow$ optimization

General ∂ CBD optimization problem

General ∂ CBD Optimization Problem

$$\min_{\theta} \mathcal{J}(Y(t), U(t), X(t); \theta) + w_{\text{reg}} \mathcal{R}(\theta)$$

$$\text{s.t. } (X(t), Y(t)) \in \text{Exec}(\mathcal{D}(\theta), U(t)), \quad \text{where}$$

$$\text{dynamics: } \begin{cases} \dot{X}^{(0)}(t) = f^{(0)}(X(t), U(t); \theta), & t \in \mathcal{T}, \\ X_{k+1}^{(\tau)} = f^{(\tau)}(X_k, U_k; \theta), & \tau > 0, k \in \mathcal{T}, \end{cases}$$

$$\text{outputs: } Y(t) = g(X(t), U(t); \theta),$$

$$\text{contracts: } \mathcal{C}^{\text{res}}(X(t), U(t), Y(t); \theta) \leq 0, \quad \forall t \in \mathcal{T}.$$

AD-compatible relaxation

$$\min_{\theta} \mathcal{L}(\theta) = \mathcal{J} + w_{\text{reg}} \mathcal{R} + w_{\mathcal{C}} \Phi_{\beta}(\mathcal{C}^{\text{res}})$$

This general formulation covers constrained system identification, policy learning, control co-design, physics-informed machine learning, and differentiable optimization workflows.

Three examples: same ∂ CBD recipe, different guarantees

Example	Contract	Optimization mechanism
1: Scalar feedback gain	Input-to-state stability (ISS)	Projected gradient onto stable interval
2: Neural policy with Lyapunov certificate	Trajectory-level Lyapunov decrease	Penalty on residual
3: Stable deep Koopman system identification	Latent operator stability $\ K\ _2 < 1$	Stability-by-construction via parameterization of K



Example 1: Stability-by-construction gain tuning

Closed-loop scalar plant

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{cl}} = \circ(\mathcal{B}_{\Sigma}; \mathcal{B}_C; \mathcal{B}_P)$$

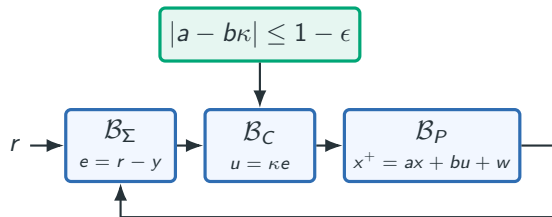
$$\mathcal{B}_P: x_{k+1} = ax_k + bu_k + w_k, y_k = x_k$$

$$\mathcal{B}_C: u_k = \kappa(e_k)$$

$$\mathcal{B}_{\Sigma}: e_k = r_k - y_k$$

Stability residual

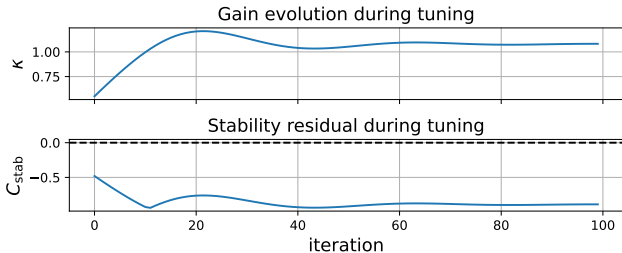
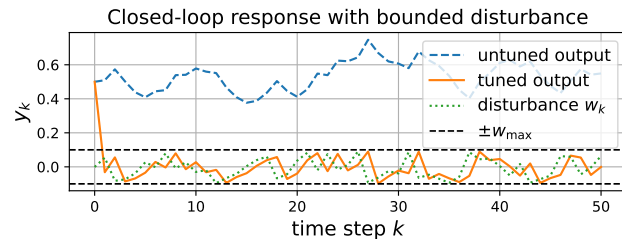
$$\mathcal{C}_{\text{stab}}^{\text{res}}(\kappa, a, b) = |a - b\kappa| - (1 - \epsilon) \leq 0$$



This is a **parameter-level certificate**: stability is built into the closed-loop system dynamics.

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{\kappa \in \mathbb{R}} \quad & \mathcal{J}(\kappa) := \sum_{k=0}^N (\|y_k\|^2 + \lambda_u \|u_k\|^2), \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & (U, Y) \in \text{Exec}(\mathcal{B}_{\text{cl}}(\kappa), W), \\ & \mathcal{C}_{\text{stab}}^{\text{res}}(\kappa, a, b) \leq 0. \end{aligned}$$

Example 1: Stability-by-construction gain tuning



Training improves performance while preserving the stability contract $C_{\text{stab}}^{\text{res}} \leq 0$.

Example 2: Joint neural policy and Lyapunov certificate

Closed-loop CBD

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{cl}}^{\text{vdp}} = \circlearrowleft (\mathcal{B}_{\pi}; \mathcal{B}_P; \mathcal{B}_V)$$

$$\mathcal{B}_{\pi} : u_k = \pi_{\Theta}(x_k)$$

$$\mathcal{B}_P : x_{k+1} = f(x_k, u_k)$$

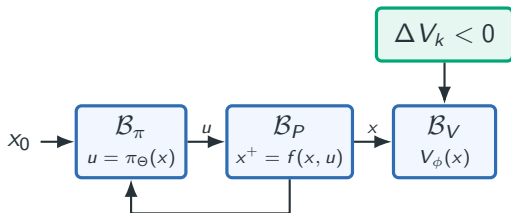
$$\mathcal{B}_V : V_{\phi}(x_k)$$

$$\theta = (\Theta, \phi)$$

Lyapunov residual

$$\mathcal{C}_{\text{lyap}}^{\text{res}}(X; \phi) =$$

$$\max_k [V_{\phi}(x_{k+1}) - V_{\phi}(x_k) + \varepsilon] \leq 0$$



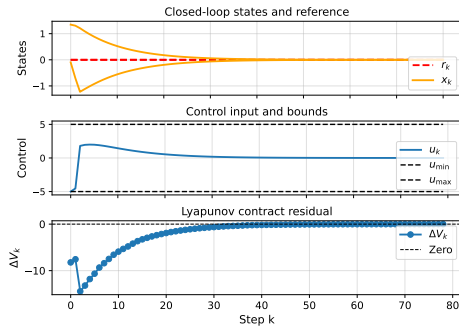
The residual is a **trajectory-level certificate**: it certifies the realized rollout.

$$\min_{\theta} \quad \mathcal{J}(\theta) := \sum_{k \in \mathcal{T}} \|x_k\|^2$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad (X, U, V) \in \text{Exec}\left(\mathcal{B}_{\text{cl}}^{\text{vdp}}(\theta), x_0\right),$$

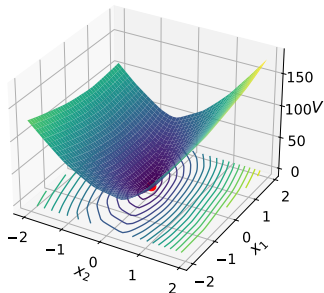
$$\mathcal{C}_{\text{lyap}}(X; \phi) \leq 0, \quad u_{\min} \leq u_k \leq u_{\max}, \quad \forall k \in \mathcal{T}.$$

Example 2: Joint neural policy and Lyapunov certificate



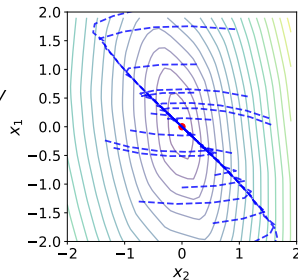
Closed-loop rollout

neural control with Lyapunov contract



Learned certificate

Lyapunov landscape and level sets



Joint optimization of policy π_Θ and certificate V_ϕ produces stable closed-loop trajectories satisfying the trajectory-wise residual contract $\mathcal{C}_{\text{lyap}}^{\text{res}} \leq 0$.

Example 3: Stable-by-construction Deep Koopman identification

Koopman CBD

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{koop}}(\theta) = (\mathcal{B}_{\text{enc}}(\theta_1); \mathcal{B}_K(\theta_2); \mathcal{B}_{\text{dec}}(\theta_3))$$

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{enc}}(\theta_1): z_k = \text{NN}_{\theta_1}(y_k)$$

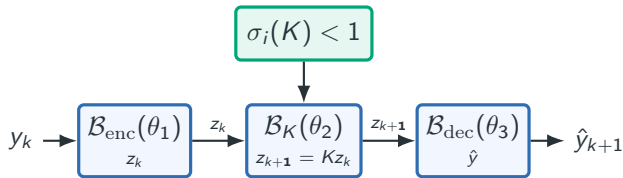
$$\mathcal{B}_K(\theta_2): z_{k+1} = K(\theta_2)z_k$$

$$\mathcal{B}_{\text{dec}}(\theta_3): \hat{y}_k = \text{NN}_{\theta_3}(z_k)$$

Stability contract

$$\mathcal{C}_{\text{stab}}(K) = \|K\|_2 - 1 \leq 0$$

Enforced by bounded singular-value parameterization.

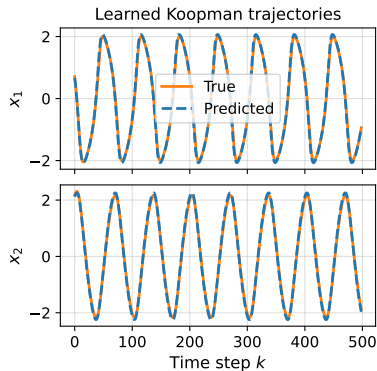


This is a **parameter-level certificate**: stability is built into the latent dynamics.

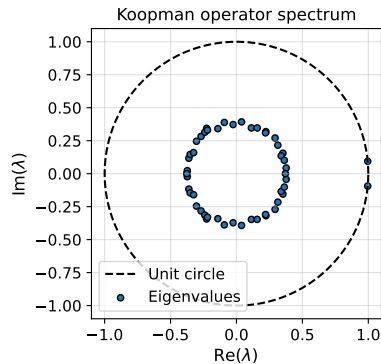
$$\min_{\theta} \mathcal{J}(\theta) := \sum_{i=1}^m (\ell_y^i + \ell_{\text{lin}}^i + \ell_{\text{recon}}^i)$$

$$\text{s.t. } (X^i, Y^i) \in \text{Exec}(\mathcal{B}_{\text{koop}}(\theta), \hat{Y}_0^i), \quad i = 1, \dots, m, \\ \mathcal{C}_{\text{stab}}(K(\theta_2)) \leq 0.$$

Example 3: Stable-by-construction Deep Koopman identification



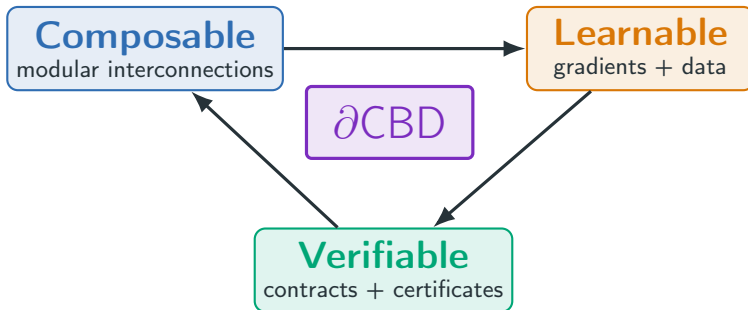
Prediction accuracy
true vs. Koopman rollouts



Stability certificate
spectrum of the learned Koopman operator

The learned Koopman model accurately predicts nonlinear dynamics while enforcing the parameter-level contract $\mathcal{C}_{\text{stab}}(K) \leq 0$, ensuring all eigenvalues remain inside the unit disk.

Takeaway: ∂ CBD unifies three semantics into coherent framework



Practical impact

∂ CBDs provide a path from causal block diagrams to modern differentiable programming while retaining semantics for modular composition and verification.

Current scope

- Algebraic loops assumed absent or handled by delay / fixed-point blocks
- Residual contracts support system-level certificates only in special cases
- Scalability depends on execution graph, verification backend, and optimizer

Future directions

- Explicit algebraic-loop semantics and implicit differentiation
- Richer contract refinement and compositional proof rules
- Large-scale CPS case studies and toolchain integration

Long-term vision: compositional, certifiable scientific machine learning (SciML) for CPS.

Thank you

Questions?

∂ CBDs: composable diagrams, differentiable execution, contract-aware learning

Backup: A–G serial compatibility

For serial connection $\sigma_{1,2}$, upstream guarantees must supply signals admissible to downstream assumptions:

$$\sigma_{1,2}(\pi_{Y_1^\sigma}(\{(U_1, Y_1) \in \mathcal{G}_1 \mid U_1 \in \mathcal{A}_1\})) \subseteq \pi_{\sigma_{1,2}^{\text{in}}}(\mathcal{A}_2).$$

Interpretation

If block 1 promises an output under its assumptions, that output must satisfy the assumptions required by block 2.

Backup: implicit differentiation for solver blocks

For a fixed-point block

$$Y^* = \Phi(Y^*, U),$$

assuming $I - \partial_Y \Phi$ is nonsingular,

$$(I - \partial_Y \Phi) \delta Y^* = \partial_U \Phi \delta U, \quad J_{Y^*, U} = (I - \partial_Y \Phi)^{-1} \partial_U \Phi.$$

Message

Implicit solver blocks can expose JVP/VJP through linear solves rather than unrolling every iteration.

Backup: differentiable optimization layers

For parametric optimization

$$Y^*(U) = \arg \min_Y \ell(Y, U) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad h(Y, U) = 0,$$

KKT conditions define

$$K(Y^*, \lambda^*, U) = 0.$$

Under regularity,

$$\partial_{(Y, \lambda)} K \begin{bmatrix} \delta Y^* \\ \delta \lambda^* \end{bmatrix} + \partial_U K \delta U = 0.$$

Message

Optimization layers are valid ∂ CBD blocks when they expose differentiable solution maps.

Backup: speaker narrative in one slide

1. CPS engineers already use block diagrams, but learning and verification live elsewhere.
2. ∂ CBDs add contracts and derivative semantics directly to blocks.
3. Compositions preserve causality and contract structure.
4. Finite-horizon executions compile to AD-ready DAGs.
5. Residual contracts become differentiable objectives or constraints.
6. Examples show exact and trajectory-level stability certificates inside one optimization pipeline.